BHOPAL

The Template Is Half Empty

By Rahul Noronha

It is something the Shivraj Singh Chouhan government in Madhya Pradesh has been struggling with for 15 years. Bhopal, the hill-ringed state capital that was once known as one of India's greenest cities, has witnessed the same unchecked boom that has bespoiled urban landscapes elsewhere. And if that cries out for a Master Plan—a grid of rules to tame the metastasising concrete—the failure to notify one has not shown the government in a flattering light. In June, hope sprang anew as the Shivraj dispensation initiated the process of bringing in a plan, but even this might turn out to be a false dawn. Sceptics feel the plan may not go through in the shape envisaged now. Reason: some of its provisions ruffle the feathers of the state's rich and powerful.

Voted as one of India's most scenic and liveable cities in multiple government and private surveys, Bhopal has been growing haphazardly, and that too in an ecologically dangerous manner, since the mid-2000s. Mostly because the Master Plan in force has outlived its validity by almost 20 years. A city's Master Plan is the guiding document that allows or disallows various types of land use—be it residential, commercial, industrial or institutional—besides regulating building heights and earmarking parking and other open spaces. Bhopal's past reputation had been no accident: meticulously laid out after it became the state capital in 1956, careful planning and near-total zero tolerance for illegal constructions or violation of land use norms were integral in creating that. These are now disappearing fast. Various government agencies have been turning a blind eye to violations of the old plan. Each minor transgression was a step towards ruination.

In 2008, as CM, Chouhan was close to finalising a Master Plan, but withdrew it after environmentalists like the late IAS officer M.N. Buch objected to allowing construction around the Ramsar-designated Upper Lake. (The Ramsar Convention is an intergovernmental treaty that provides the framework for conservation of wetlands and their resources.) The plan was shelved; Chouhan ruled for 10 more years but never revisited it. In 2020, the Congress government led by Kamal Nath released a draft, but the government soon collapsed and, with Chouhan back in the saddle, the issue remained on the backburner. Sources say chief secretary Iqbal Singh Bains convinced the CM to reconsider the Master Plan urgently, but with some key changes to the 2020 draft.

Taking a pro-people and pro-residents view, the draft proposes to allow only residential land use in certain key residential areas. These include the posh Arera Colony, Shamla Hills and Vijay Nagar. When these areas were planned, the layout of the houses and roads did not provide for large parking spaces as

A DRAFT MASTER PLAN IS OPPOSED BY POWERFUL LOBBIES OF POLITICIANS AND BUREAUCRATS



MINDLESS GROWTH An aerial view of Bhopal along the Upper Lake

IN A LIMBO...

The many plans but nil action for Bhopal

Jun. 1995: Bhopal Development Plan 1995-2005 with a population projection of 2.5 million comes into force

2008: The state government begins finalising a new plan. The draft 'Bhopal Development Plan 2021' is released, but annulled at the stage of hearing objections and suggestions. Shivraj never revisits it till the end of his tenure

Mar. 2020: Work towards a Master Plan restarts under Kamal Nath. The draft 'Bhopal Development Plan 2031' is issued